

Sept 21 Tragedy

A brief history of pi losing its hands

What Broke

Pi (the coding agent CLI) auto-updated itself this week. In the new version, pi no longer hands a provider extension a simple list of “here are the tools” and “here's the system prompt.” Instead, it bundles both into the conversation history itself, and expects the provider's code to pull them back out with a helper function. All of pi's own built-in providers were updated to do this. The MIT Parley extension wasn't — it was written for the old, simpler way — so every request it sent to Parley silently went out with no tools and, for most models, no system prompt at all. The AI didn't error out; it just pretended to read and write files while doing nothing.

The Fix

The extension's request-building code (`dist/stream.js`) was patched to fetch tools and the system prompt using pi's new helper functions (`getCurrentTools`, `getInitialSystemMessage`) instead of reading them directly off the old fields. Verified with live tests that file reads, writes, and commands now actually happen.

What the Maintainer Needs to Do

The bug lives in the `mit-parley-pi-extension` npm package — the pi provider extension that routes pi through MIT's Parley gateway. Its maintainer is **prash**, and the source repo is:

```
git@github.mit.edu:prash/pi_parley.git
```

In that repo's source (`src/stream.ts`, not just the installed `dist/` copy):

- 1 Import `getCurrentTools`, `getInitialSystemMessage`, and `withoutInitialSystemMessage` from `@earendil-works/pi-ai`.
- 2 Wherever the code reads `context.tools`, replace it with `getCurrentTools(context.messages)`.
- 3 Wherever it reads `context.systemPrompt`, replace it with `getInitialSystemMessage(context.messages)?.content`, and strip that leading message before mapping the rest.
- 4 Publish a new npm version so the fix survives future pi updates.

Incident date: September 21, 2026